

Sardana Ivanova

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Applied Scientist with 7 years of experience in two universities and several companies, including 1 year leading a team of 3 engineers. Proficient in Python and deep learning frameworks. Experienced with Generative AI and LLMs. Designed, implemented and launched a Danish tax law assistant using Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG).

Experience

Chief Science Officer

Populous Analytics — Danish lawtech startup

Helsinki (remote)
Dec 2023 – Jan 2025

- Designed and deployed a RAG-based GenAI chatbot using OpenAI GPT.
- Fine-tuned open-source models (Mistral, Llama) with quantization and low-rank adaptation (LoRA).
- Led a team of 3 engineers; managed full development lifecycle using Agile methodologies.
- Transitioned product from prototype to paid subscription service.
- Created comprehensive documentation and service catalog.

NLP Specialist

Kasvu Labs — Finnish IT startup

Helsinki
Dec 2022 – Oct 2023

- Worked on natural language processing tasks including summarization, emotion classification, emotions categorisation, and hard and soft skills detection for mental health and smart recruitment applications.

Doctoral Researcher

University of Helsinki

Helsinki
Jan 2019 – Mar 2024

- Trained Finnish, Swedish and English poetry-generation models used in an exhibit at the Heureka science center.
- Led creation of a question-answering dataset for Norwegian during a research visit to the University of Oslo.
- Trained machine translation models for Turkic languages.

Education

University of Helsinki

PhD in Computer Science

Helsinki
2024

Dissertation: “Language Technology Tools for Low-Resource Languages—Five Cases for Sakha, Norwegian, and Finnish”

<http://hdl.handle.net/10138/572878>

Skills

- Python, PyTorch
- Large language model APIs: OpenAI, Mistral, LLaMA
- Model training, evaluation, and deployment
- Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)
- Cloud: Google Cloud Platform
- Web frameworks: FastAPI
- Databases: SQL and NoSQL, FAISS vector database

Language Skills: English fluent, Sakha native, Russian native, Finnish intermediate, Japanese intermediate

Selected Publications

- NorQuAD: Norwegian Question Answering Dataset. S. Ivanova et al. NoDaLiDa 2023.
- A Large-Scale Study of Machine Translation in Turkic Languages. J. Mirzakhlov, ..., S. Ivanova et al. EMNLP 2021.
- One Line at a Time: Generation and Internal Evaluation of Interactive Poetry. M. Boggia, S. Ivanova et al. ICCV 2022.